

SIPRA DAS



SHIVRAJ PATIL | UNION HOME MINISTER

Serial Blunderer

It takes a lot to ruffle the carefully combed visage of India's home minister. His first response to the crisis was to dismiss it as a law and order problem way back in June. Two months later, when the local problem became a national crisis, angry cabinet colleagues upbraided him in a UPA meeting. Lalu Yadav asked, "Why did the home ministry fail to anticipate the situation particularly while dealing with such a sensitive state?" Another minister muttered that the home minister's briefings sounded more like All India Radio bulletins. But that didn't dent Patil's manicured countenance either. It was not the first time he had been damned by his colleagues.

It was on August 7, two months after the first protester was killed, the Centre held its first all-party meeting on the issue. It was also as late as August that the Army was sent

in and curfew imposed in the state. Such is the prime minister's faith in his own home minister that he initially toyed with the idea of rushing in External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee along with Patil to the state but balked when told that this act could give it an international aura. Patil's first sign as a negotiator was to cave in immediately when the samiti insisted that the delegation's three Muslim members—Mehbooba Mufti, Farooq Abdullah and Saifuddin Soz—should not be a part of the talks. Not surprisingly, the talks remained inconclusive.

Already a target of the BJP following the serial blasts, Patil has strengthened the case for his ouster with his inept handling of the Kashmir crisis. He prefers bureaucratic obfuscations instead of plain talk; he is his own worst defence. His failure is complete: in words, in attitude, in action. **by Priya Sahgal**

"AT TIMES, WE FEEL IT COULD HAVE BEEN BETTER HAD WE BEEN ABLE TO AVERT A HAPPENING OF THIS NATURE."

Shivraj Patil, Union Home Minister

SYED ALI SHAH GEELANI | SEPARATIST LEADER

Voice of Pakistan

Last year, an ailing Syed Ali Shah Geelani underwent treatment for kidney cancer in the US after the Government issued him passport considering his medical condition as well as marginalised status in Kashmir. As he recovers, the Amarnath land row has come as a lifeline for the Hurriyat hawk, catapulting him from the shadows to the centre stage of the latest anti-India mass frenzy in the Valley.

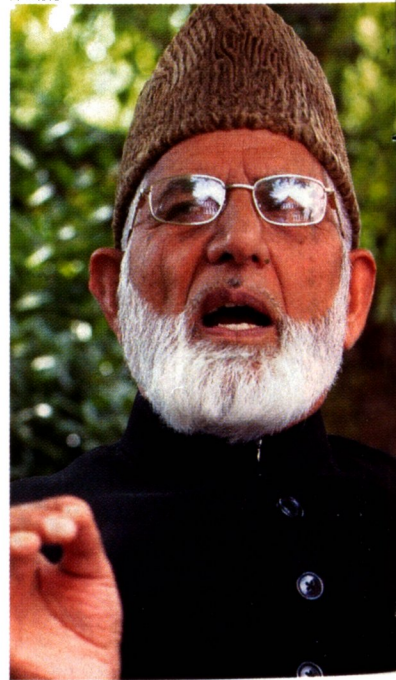
In fact, it was the state government's controversial decision to transfer land to the shrine board that brought the two bickering Hurriyat factions together. The moderate Mirwaiz Umar Farooq and hardliner Geelani met for lunch in June for the first time in over four years to resurrect their lost cause by whipping up a dramatic upsurge in

separatist sentiment across Kashmir. A shrewd rabble rouser, Geelani was quick to take full advantage of the political vacuum during the governor's rule.

After Governor N.N. Vohra rescinded the land transfer order, Geelani changed tack and pegged the separatists propaganda to the so-called "economic blockade" of the Valley—an emotive issue that roused passions and cut wide swathe across Kashmir. Even more provocative was his Muzaffarabad March exhortation to fruit traders to breach the LOC as a symbolic protest of their pro-Pakistan leanings. Clearly, Geelani couldn't have asked for a more potent issue to revive his relevance and keep the separatist pot boiling.

by Ramesh Vinayak

AP PHOTO



"INDIA IS TRYING TO CHANGE THE DEMOGRAPHIC STATUS OF KASHMIR AND TAKING AWAY LAND FROM KASHMIRIS."

Syed Ali Shah Geelani, Separatist Leader